

PRESCHOOL CHILD DEVELOPMENT: IMPLICATIONS FOR INVESTIGATION OF CHILD ABUSE ALLEGATIONS

ABIGAIL B. SIVAN

Department of Psychiatry and Department of Psychology and Social Sciences, Rush Medical College
and Rush-Presbyterian-St. Luke's Medical Center, Chicago, IL

Abstract—Allegations of mistreatment by adults made by children of preschool age are often dismissed as fictitious with the suggestion that children of this age are prone to fantasy and unable to discriminate fact from fiction. This paper is intended to familiarize those with a general concern about child abuse with the research and theories in child development. Specifically, it reviews those aspects of normal child development which have direct relevance to the question of the veracity of reports made by children ages 2 to 5 years. Examination of the research on children's thought and language, memory and learning, fears, fantasy, and play, as well as the research on the influence of television on children of this age, led to the conclusion that preschoolers base their play on the reality of their experience.

Key Words—Abuse allegations, Child abuse, Child development, Child maltreatment, Preschool.

INTRODUCTION

WHILE BOTH PROFESSIONALS and the general public have become more informed about the problems of child abuse, it is still difficult to accept the possibility that adults harm children and do so in creative and unusual ways. In the recent past, newspapers and television have presented the details of criminal cases involving molestation of large groups of preschoolers in diverse geographical locations (Florida, California, Illinois) and described allegations of abuse in the context of rituals involving costumes, chants, and sacrificial activities. There is a bias among some professionals to dismiss children's allegations of sexual abuse with the suggestion that the report was fabricated by the child for secondary gain (Everson & Boat, 1989). In the press and in the courtroom, such allegations are dismissed with the suggestion that preschoolers are particularly prone to fantasy and/or are especially vulnerable to the influence of television; as a consequence, their allegations are judged fictitious and unbelievable.

The following is a brief review summarizing those aspects of child development research which set the context for evaluating the question of veracity in allegations by preschool children. This review does not focus on child abuse research per se nor on questions such as suggestibility (Goodman & Aman, 1987; Bottoms et al., 1989) which have been raised by investigations of child abuse. Rather this review will examine data and theories about thinking and language, memory and learning, fears, fantasy, and play in the preschool years, that is

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Requests for reprints should be sent to A. B. Sivan, Ph.D., 1720 West Polk St., Chicago, IL 60612.

for children between the ages of 2 and 5 years old. In addition, it will review briefly what is known about the influence of television on children of this age.

It is important to note that, strictly speaking, child psychology and developmental psychology are not synonymous terms. However, for the purposes of this review, they will be used interchangeably to refer to those fields of study that address the questions of *what children do and say, at what ages, and how they do what they do*. Precisely in the area of cognition and thinking the two fields overlap with one focusing more on global observations and descriptions of the sequence of child behavior and the other focusing on necessarily limited experimental studies which explore details of a given stage or transition in the orderly sequence of child development.

REVIEW

Thought and Language

Children are neither miniature nor incomplete adults. They make sense out of the world in a manner different from that of adults. The pioneering work of Jean Piaget, Swiss psychologist and philosopher, directed attention to the qualitative differences among children of different ages with respect to their thinking (Ginsburg & Oppen, 1969; Piaget, 1962, 1963a, 1963b, 1967; Richmond, 1970). Piaget maintained that the thinking of the preschool child is preconceptual—that is, although the preschool child is no longer tied to the experiential and sensory-motor stimuli of the early years, s/he has not yet fully mastered symbolization or representation.

The early years from birth until about the age of 2 years are characterized by a reliance on movement and action as means of interacting with and making sense out of the world. Piaget made the observation that these actions are organized into what he called schemata. Preschoolers are no longer solely dependent on these sensorimotor schemata; instead, they take these sequences of behavior into contexts which differ from those in which they were first learned. This is accomplished through what Piaget referred to as *delayed imitation* and by the use of substitute objects to represent both objects and people in the environment. Some representation is achieved through *pretend play*; most is achieved through the development of language. Words function as signs and are able to represent actions, objects, and people in their absence. Early language development is characterized by its privacy in the sense that initially children have difficulty separating out exemplars from classes. For example, “daddy” can be used for all adult males, while “dog” may be used to represent only the child’s own dog and not the class of animals which includes the neighbor’s pet as well. There has been much experimental research addressing which attributes are learned and in what order; however, a detailed discussion of this work is beyond the scope of this review.

There has also been debate about the reciprocity between thought and language (Vygotsky, 1962); the question of what influences what and in which ways is still a matter to be resolved. Cairns and Valsiner (1984) suggest that the child does not carry knowledge around in his head; rather he has a “computer” in his head which acts on experiences and constructs interpretations and accounts of experiences passing by and finally plans adaptive behavior. Knowledge is built on action and consists of plans for actions. It is useful to view languages and its rules simultaneously as actions offered by the child to the outside world (accommodation) and as experiences which the child processes from the outside world (assimilation).

Some characteristics highlight the essence of preconceptual thought and language; these are outlined below with examples taken from Richmond (1970) (the child’s age is in parentheses next to the example):

1. *Transductive reasoning*, when children try to make judgments by moving from one pre-concept to another preconcept. EXAMPLES: (2:4) "Daddy's getting hot water, so he's going to shave."
(4:10) "I haven't had my nap so it isn't afternoon."
2. *Juxtaposition*, when children collect attributes of objects and situations and use the collection to define cause and effect. EXAMPLES: (6:0) "I lost my pen because I'm not writing."
(4:0) In answer to the question what makes the engine go,
"The smoke."
"What smoke?"
"The smoke from the funnel."
3. *Syncretism*, when something is represented as relating or connecting to everything else without differentiation. EXAMPLES: (4:0) "How does a bicycle go?"
"With wheels."
"And the wheels?"
"They go round."
"How do they turn?"
"It's the bicycle that makes them turn."
4. *Centration*, when children concentrate on one dimension at a time. Lack of conservation or the inability to appreciate the sameness of an object despite a change in its shape or spatial arrangement is a prime example of this phenomenon.
5. *Egocentricity*, which operates when children assume that others see the world in the same manner as they do. Referents are assumed to be shared by all, and thinking itself is never an object of thought. EXAMPLES: (4:6) "Have you got a sister?"
"Yes."
"And has she got a sister?"
"No, she hasn't got a sister. I am my sister."

Three other characteristics play a part in the child's egocentricity. These are *animism* or the imparting of feelings or actions to objects; *artificialism* or the ascribing to outside agents the creation of events; and *participation* or the connecting of human actions with the action of things. EXAMPLES: (Animism: 3:7) "It comes with us to look at us" (referring to the sun).
(Artificialism: 6:0) "Why are there waves on the lake?"

"Because they've been put there."

(Participation: 4:6) "I'm stamping (my foot), because if I don't, the soup isn't good enough. If I do, the soup's good."

Piaget divided language into language for communication and egocentric speech. The latter is essentially self-serving and accompanies actions. Communicative or socialized speech is characterized by the desire to communicate with others but is hampered by the cognitive limitations discussed earlier. As the child moves to a more conceptual level of thought, words gradually attain more shared meanings, while symbols and images become more personal. At the preconceptual level, however, words, images, and symbols are in the same category and consist of a mixture of partially shared/partially personal meanings.

The learning of vocabulary is social, and highly dependent on interaction with others speaking the same language. The learning of syntactical rules is more dependent on maturation. Early speech is characterized by one- or two-word phrases, and in the third year, children begin adding grammatical morphemes to their phrases. These morphemes represent features such as time (tenses) and number (plurals); the rules that govern their usage are sometimes overgeneralized, and it amuses us to hear words such as "runned" or "mouses". By the fourth year, children are using the future tense; their phrases are becoming longer and more complex with two or more ideas imbedded into one sentence. The syntactic structures themselves

convey meaning and the child's sense of the order of things is reflected in his speech and expressions.

In summary, in respect to the thought and language of preschoolers, it is known that they are constantly trying to make sense out of the world around them. At first they try to make sense of the world through movement and action; in the preschool years, they do this with the development of symbols and other forms of representation. Language is a powerful form of representation, and with it comes many cultural expectations and shared meanings.

It is also known that both language and thought are organized by rules and that their acquisition is, in part, governed by the rapidity with which these rules are developed. The preschooler is in the process of developing rules and reflects his thoughts in a manner which is less logical than the reasoning of adults. For this reason, the stories young children tell are not as coherent and do not flow as well as those that are told by older children.

Memory and Learning

Because the long-term storage of information has been assumed to be a verbally based process, the reliability of the memory of young children has always been suspect. In a recent review, Fundudis (1989) denies the validity of this assumption and carefully delineates the memory abilities of children under a wide variety of conditions. The main points of his review are summarized below. Memory is not a unitary concept; there are different kinds of memories, and each needs to be addressed separately. *Recognition* memory is that memory required when a person is asked whether or not a physical stimulus is present or not (Have you seen this person or that object before?). Children as young as 4 or 5 years of age do as well as older children on recognition tasks such as picture or fact recognition (Saywitz, 1987). In fact, there is one published account of a 3 year old recognizing an assailant in a photo line-up (Jones & Krugman, 1986). Preschoolers are able to recognize previously experienced locations as well as older children. However, remembering voices appears to be particularly difficult for both older and younger children.

Free recall memory involves recounting, rather than simply recognizing, information or events from the past. Preschool children tend to do poorly on this, when compared to adolescents and adults. It is not that children are less accurate in their accounts, but that their recollections contain much less information. Thus their errors are viewed as errors of omission rather than commission. However, when given appropriate cues, it has been found young children are able to remember accurately details not reported earlier in free recall situation (Saywitz, 1987).

There are two important variants of free recall memory: *episodic memory* and *script memory*. Episodic memory refers to memories of specific details about times, dates, and locations, and requires the understanding of abstract concepts such as time, duration, sequence, and succession. Research has demonstrated that only in the school years are children able to appreciate and make accurate judgments about time (Fraisse, 1963). Younger children are tied to regular behavioral routines (e.g., bedtime, mealtime) rather than to clocks or calendars. For this reason, having the child identify his or her favorite TV shows and using these as anchors in the time continuum is sometimes helpful.

Script memory refers to the recall of a past event in a free manner, one in which the person is free to report details which are personally relevant rather than specifics which are demanded by an interviewer. Script memory allows for descriptions of those events accompanying a given type of situation such as "eating in a restaurant" or "when the babysitter comes" and detailed questioning follows the child's spontaneous version of events. Children as young as 35 months have been found to accurately relate some events occurring from 1 month to over a

year previously. Repeated exposure to an event brings about a more elaborate script; however, specifics of a given instance may still be lacking from a child's telling of the event.

Thus far, the discussion has suggested that the accuracy of children's memories for past events is a function of the child's age, the type of memory required, and the context or concrete cues for memory access. Chi (1983) introduced another dimension in her review. She examined those instances in which children possess more knowledge than adults. Studies of chess masters suggest that experience and knowledge, and not age, is relevant to memory and retrieval of knowledge related to chess playing; in fact, in these experiments adult memory looked very much like that of children when the adults were working in a field of knowledge with which they were not familiar. An adult can no more learn a piece of knowledge without its prerequisites than can a child. In fact, the performances of children and adults are reversed when the material to be recalled is familiar to the child and unfamiliar to the adult. However, since adults usually have a greater fund of knowledge than children, they learn faster than children.

In regard to memory and learning, we know that when allowed to relate a tale in his/her own words the preschool child does not create a false picture. Not yet socialized into the relevancy of certain important features of a situation, preschool children may ignore features in the telling. However when prompted, they can add relevant and true details. Cognitive limitations related to knowledge of time and sequence make a child's version of a story qualitatively different from that of an adult. However, research has shown that in those situations in which children have more knowledge than adults the performances of adults and children reverse themselves and the children produce more elaborate and exact recollections than do the adults.

For the most part, the research discussed was done under laboratory conditions not mimicking the unusual and sometimes painful conditions of abuse. Goodman and her associates (Goodman & Aman, 1987; Bottoms et al., 1989) as well as Pynoos and his group (Pynoos & Eth, 1984; Pynoos & Nader, 1989) have explored memory in nonstandard conditions. A discussion of their findings is beyond the scope of this review.

Fears

While few research studies examine the developmental nature of fears, there are plenty of case studies in the clinical and psychoanalytic literature on abnormal fears, and there are also some surveys of stress felt by children in competitive situations such as the school setting. Many years ago Bauer (1976) published his research exploring the normal development of fears. He asked children of three different age groups—4–6 years old, 6–8 years old, 10–12 years old—to answer and discuss three questions: (1) "All of us are afraid of something but we are afraid of some things more than others. What are you afraid of most? Draw a picture and tell me about it. (2) Sometimes we are afraid when we go to bed at night. Are you afraid when you go to bed at night? What are you afraid of? Tell me about it. (3) Sometimes after we go to bed at night and have fallen asleep we have dreams. Sometimes dreams scare me. Did a dream ever scare you? Draw a picture and tell me about it." Fifty-four children were interviewed, and their interviews taped for later analysis.

Bauer's findings indicated a sequence in the development of fears that proceeds from a global state, with a lack of specificity, to one of increased realism. Both the kindergartners and second graders expressed fears of monsters, ghosts, and animals. They readily endorsed experiencing bedtime fears and frightening dreams. In contrast, the fears of sixth graders were more realistic and included fears of bodily injury and of physical danger. Sex differences were noted in the responses of the older boys and girls; most of the sixth grade boys categorically denied

the presence of frightening dreams, and many fewer boys than girls reported the presence of bedtime fears.

Kindergarten-age children tended to identify the appearance of an object ("because he looks ugly") as a sufficient condition for regarding that object as threatening, while older children would use hypothesized actions as indications of potential harm ("guess he would have choked me or something"). It is notable that the findings of this study were so consistent with Piaget's descriptions of syncretic thinking and fusion of qualities. Older children used physical causality in their reasoning while the younger children offered imaginary themes such as fear of ghosts and monsters with little realism and vagueness in their actions.

Play and Fantasy

Paralleling the development of language, play has both egocentric aspects in which children play next to each other without interaction and more social aspects in which play progresses from associative and syncretic interaction to truly cooperative interaction and rule-governed games (Howes, Unger, & Seidner, 1989).

Bretherton (1984) has presented a collection of detailed studies of the content of children's play. Some of these studies have elaborated what children understand about the behavior of other people—their activities, feelings, perceptions, and thoughts. Other studies have focused on the sequence and frequency of fantasy play. One study examined three types of play: reality play or the use of objects for their intended purpose, object fantasy or the attribution of an entirely new identity to an object, and person fantasy or the portrayal of characters (Cole & LaVoie, 1985). During the preschool years, object fantasy was found to be most popular with the younger (2- and 3-year-old) children and with the oldest (6-year-old) children, while person fantasy appeared to follow a linear trend from 3 to 5 years of age and to decrease after age 6 years. This research supports other reports of fantasy play as well as Piaget's descriptions of the sequence of development.

In 1989, the McArthur Foundation honored Vivian Gussin Paley, a preschool teacher in Chicago. Ms. Paley is no ordinary teacher; she is a careful observer and chronicler of the dramatic play of the preschool child. *Boys and Girls: Superheroes in the Doll Corner* (Paley, 1984) gives a penetrating view of the ways in which children take characters from stories and television and use them for their own purposes. Paley's own summary is quoted here as paraphrasing does her a disservice:

[At age three] costumes representing male and female roles are casually exchanged. Everyone cooks and eats pretend food together. Mother, father, and baby are the primary actors, but identities shift and participants seldom keep one another informed. . . .

By the age of four, the players are more inclined to tell one another why they are and what they are doing. They want to coordinate themes, but it is not always possible, because the boys are beginning to rebel. . . .

The four-year-old boy is less comfortable in the doll corner than he was the year before; he may occasionally dress up in women's clothes or agree to be Daddy, but the superhero clique has formed, and the doll corner is becoming a woman's room. For their part, four-year-old girls may intermittently exchange domestic roles for Wonderwoman and Supergirl, but Mother and Baby reign supreme and will continue to do so throughout kindergarten.

The atmosphere in the doll corner changes dramatically among five- and six-year olds. . . . As the superhero dominates boys' fantasy play, the girls turn to dramatic plots that eliminate boys and bring in more sisters and princesses.

Boys set the tone, and girls follow on parallel paths. Both seek a new social definition for "boy" and "girl." They search everywhere for clues, hoping to create separate and final images. Society supplies Barbie dolls and Star Wars, but the children invent equally interesting symbols for themselves (ix-xi).

Paley describes a 3-year-old discovering the "monster," telling his first stories about a "great big big big monster purple and orange that ate people and houses," and play-acting the monster as a nameless creature roaming around looking for someone to scare. The "some-

ones" are always girls; girls can never be monsters. When Superman, Batman and Mighty Mouse join the monster a short time later, there are no visible differences. Both monsters and heroes go "Bang Bang" with fingers and sticks because no guns are allowed. All the characters are aggressive, villainous, active, and usually associated with being a boy; but there are times when girls also play at being powerful. In one humorous sequence, Paley describes a queen of the police station, with police sisters, babies, and monsters.

Paley's book is fascinating and easy to read. The message is clear: The dramatic play of children is a reflection of their cognitive development, of the social issues with which they are grappling, and of those environmental stimuli such as television and books that impinge daily on their lives.

The regularity of developmental sequences extends to both childhood fears and fantasy play. As age increases, fears change from the vague and undifferentiated to more realistic forms, and they are explained by higher levels of reasoning. Dramatic play also changes; it moves from the egocentric to the social, and preschool children are observed to be struggling with definitions of their gender roles in the larger scheme of things.

The Role of Television

The television is often considered a powerful influence on the imagination and fantasy of children. It has been shown that television can influence children as young as 14 months of age (Meltzoff, 1988). Moreover, television as a teacher of concepts and vocabulary (Rice & Woodsmall, 1988) has been the basis of many efforts to expand and increase education programs such as "Sesame Street," "The Electric Company," and "3-2-1 Contact."

Television has also been utilized in efforts at positive socialization with programs such as "Mr. Roger's Neighborhood." Most of the research on children's television watching has focused on the antisocial learning or aggression learned from exposure to adult programming. The research of the Singers (1981) on the effects of television on the behavior of preschool children suggests that heavy viewing has an inverse relationship with imaginativeness. In fact, less expressiveness in language and a greater trend toward overt aggression and uncooperativeness with teachers was observed in those children who spent more time before the television tube.

The researchers did not expect such a clear pattern to emerge, but the strong relationship between viewing "action shows" and attacking other children or property was a consistent pattern that could not be denied. It is beyond the scope of this paper to detail the Singers' (1980) discussion of the characteristics of those families in which little control of television watching is exerted; suffice it to say that for these families, the television set becomes "a member of the family." Its viewers consider the televised actions acceptable behaviors to be imitated, and they integrate these behaviors into their own world view.

Television is a powerful teacher of young children. It provides alternative modes for behavior from those seen in one's immediate environment. Some of these models are positive; many are not. However, exposure to television does not increase a child's creativeness or imagination.

CONCLUSIONS

From this overview, it is reasonable to conclude that statements (mainly in newspapers) about the preschooler, who "at an age when there is a particularly rich fantasy life, alleged this or that abuse" are making false assumptions. The rich fantasy life of the preschooler is over-

worked; it is a myth which perhaps was begun by Freud who did not want, any more than we do, to believe that the frightful early recollections of his patients reflected actual experience.

Most likely, the reports of young children are based on reality. The allegations of preschool children who relate detailed and terrible tales of activities perpetrated by cartoon characters are probably not made-up stories or fantasy. These tales are not the vague fears of monsters and ghosts, nor are they the aggressive and power games played out between superheroes in the doll corner. These tales are different; they are neither vague nor are they routinized interactions involving cartoon characters.

Hearing these stories is frightening to the listener because, given what is known about children's thinking, language, and memory, these children would have been exposed to the described situation on more than one occasion to be able to create such tales. If this review accomplishes nothing else, we hope that the reader will remember that the constructions of preschoolers, whether in words or play, are not likely to be pure fantasy. More likely they are based on the reality of the child's experience, and the detail which they reflect is probably directly related to the amount of experience to which the child has been exposed.

Postscript. Readers with a deeper interest in this topic are referred to a book published after the preparation of this manuscript: Garbarino, Stott and the faculty of the Erikson Institute. *What Children Can Tell Us*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 1989.

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Résumé—Les propos tenus par les enfants en âge préscolaire concernant d'éventuels mauvais traitements par des adultes sont souvent écartés sous prétexte que les enfants de cet âge sont enclins à la fantaisie et ne discernent pas les faits de la fiction. Cet article est destiné à familiariser ceux qui sont généralement concernés par les mauvais traitements aux enfants avec la recherche et les théories concernant le développement du jeune enfant. Cet article passe spécifiquement en revue les aspects du développement normal de l'enfant ayant directement trait à la véracité des dires des enfants âgés de deux à cinq ans. Après examen des données concernant les pensées et le langage des enfants, la mémoire et l'apprentissage, les peurs, la fantaisie et le jeu ainsi que l'influence de la télévision sur les enfants de cet âge, il est conclu que les enfants en âge préscolaire appuient leur jeu et leurs histoires sur la réalité de leur expérience.

Resumen—Los alegatos de maltrato hechos por niños preescolares por parte de adultos, son a menudo descartados como ficticios con la sugerencia de que los niños de esta edad están inclinados a fantasear y son incapaces de discriminar entre los hechos y la ficción. Este artículo tiene por objeto familiarizar a los lectores con las investigaciones y las teorías en el campo del desarrollo del niño. Específicamente, el artículo examina aquellos aspectos del desarrollo normal del niño que están relacionados con el problema de la veracidad de las informaciones dadas por niños de dos a cinco años de edad. Después de haber examinado los datos sobre el pensamiento, el lenguaje, la memoria, el aprendizaje, los miedos, la fantasía y el juego de los niños de esta edad, así como la influencia de la televisión sobre ellos, se concluye que los niños preescolares basan su juego y cuentos en la realidad de su experiencia.